



Modder's delight

An unobtrusive PC need not be an HTPC, you can shape it like a beaver if you so desire. <http://dgit.in/11drpQv>



BitTorrent Sync Available

BitTorrent Sync has now entered public beta and is available for download for Windows, Mac, Linux and Android. <http://dgit.in/13poGnS>

Workshop

Install Add-ons

Add-ons really enhance the functionality of the XBMC application. They add support for a host of exciting features. The open source development forums for XBMC are active and recently, there's been a surge in the number of plug-ins, skins and other feature-based add-ons. A few great ones are hosted on the official XBMC site and can be viewed and installed post installation.

XBMC.org add-ons

To access the add-ons that come pre-loaded with the installation you need to go to System > Settings > Add-ons > Get Add-ons > XBMC.org Add-ons. You can explore the list and select the add-on you want to install. Once installed you can access the add-on by clicking on the main menu and going to the sub-section of the respective add-on topic. Do check out the nifty add-ons for music, movies and TV features enhancements.

Third-party add-ons

As mentioned, loads of great third-party add-ons are available for XBMC. To install these add-ons you must first load the repository in the XBMC add-on list. To do this, simply download the third-party repository's zip file and store it in a folder than can be accessed from within XBMC. Now to load that repository go to System > Settings > Add-ons > Install from Zip file. In the dialogue box that appears, browse through the list and select the zip file from within the folder you just downloaded it into. Now select the repository you just loaded and you'll be shown a list of all the available add-ons in that repository sorted by categories such as Music, Video etc. Basically, once the repository is loaded into XBMC you can access its add-ons in the same way you'd access the official add-ons.

Customize the Skin

Now XBMC comes with quite a pretty default skin named Confluence. It looks killer on big screens as well. But if you still wish to change its skin and add a bit of color or variety to your XBMC interface you can do so easily. There are some amazing skins available, the best of which we'll

use as an example to guide you through the customisation process. To change the existing skin you must go to System > Settings > Appearance > Skins. On clicking 'Skins' on the right-hand side of the screen, you'll initially see only Confluence in the dialogue box as that's the default skin. Click on 'Get more' and go to Get

Add-ons > XBMC.org add-ons > Skins. Select your desired skin (Aeon Nox, for example) from the list. Then simply click on 'Install' in the prompt box that follows. Now return to the main menu and once again go to System > Settings > Appearance > Skin. In the dialogue box that appears, you'll now see Aeon Nox as well. Click on Aeon Nox and the skin will immediately be applied to your XBMC interface. Aeon Nox is one of the most popular skins and once you use it, you'll see why! Skins can even be loaded from an external repository.

Customise the interface

After having learnt how to change your skin, you'll now see how easily you can customize the XBMC interface as well. Basically we'll have to play around with the various settings in the Appearance section. In this tutorial we'll show you how to tweak one such setting. We'll enable the display of add-ons on the home screen itself rather than having to browse for them through various sections. It's an easy and useful tweak. Go to System > Settings > Appearance > Settings. Click on 'Skins' and in the dialogue box that appears go to the Add-ons option. Now simply browse the menu on the right-hand side section and keep clicking on the add-ons from each section that you want displayed on the home screen.

Stream video content

XBMC has some wonderful add-ons to stream media content. We'll discuss the installation of one such add-on, called Icefilms. It's basically a video plug-in that's bundled with the video add-on library of the anarchintosh repository.



The repository can be downloaded from the following link: <http://dgit.in/12SSCsW>

Download and store this repository in a suitable folder and load it into XBMC as mentioned in the section on third-party add-ons above. Once this repository is loaded, install the Icefilms add-on from the Video Add-ons section. Access this add-on from the main menu by going to Video > Add-ons. Clicking on the add-on will reveal a list containing categories such as Sports and Stand-up Comedy by which video content is sorted. You can now stream some amazing content using this plug-in. They also have TV series such as HIMYM, BBT and Family Guy! This is just an example of a really useful add-on. There are a whole lot of add-ons available with diverse features. You can stream Khan Academy videos, watch YouTube videos, stream news and what not!

This brings us to the end of this basic workshop on the XBMC application software. It's an amazing option to store all your media in one place and use it as a wholesome entertainment hub. Not only that, this open source software can help sync multiple devices of the same type within a house. With multiple devices you can pause a movie in a room and watch it where you left off in another! You can also watch Live TV using the software if you have a TV tuner card. Airplay wireless streaming is also supported on certain devices. To top it all, with some software tuning and rigorous settings you can automate downloads as well! All these powerful features combined with basic media player functionality make XBMC a must-try-out option.